

tempting targets for air attack. The weather was also favorable, with almost guaranteed clear skies. Yet it was difficult to remain cautious about the future potential of air power in the face of such outright triumph.

The first resort

For the key to the political attractiveness of air power as a military option, there is no need to look further than the Gulf War casualty list: only 200 men lost on the Coalition side in a war with the substantial armed forces of a considerable regional power. Thus, when NATO leaders became convinced in 1999 that Serbia had to be driven out of the province of Kosovo, but suspected that this was a cause for which the Western public would not be prepared to see their servicemen die, they fought the first and so far only war to be conducted exclusively by air. Despite a number of notable errors, of which the most diplomatically embarrassing was the destruction of the Chinese embassy in Belgrade, the air strikes did indeed drive the Serbians out. NATO achieved the extraordinary feat of winning a small war without sustaining a single combat casualty. For the world's most technologically advanced nations, aircraft had become the weapon of first resort.

TANK-BUSTER

The A-10 "Warthog" is an aircraft specifically designed for the close support of ground forces, and in particular for taking on enemy armored vehicles. It is relatively slow-moving but can stay over the battlefield for long periods of time and withstand a good deal of punishment from ground fire.



SPECTACLE OF DESTRUCTION

Coalition air attacks upon Iraqi ground forces (below) in the Gulf War left an awesome spectacle of destruction in their wake. Attempting to flee Kuwait City by night, the Iraqis found the road blocked by mines dropped by F/A-18s. They were then destroyed (left) by air strikes orchestrated by controllers of E-8 J-STARS air-to-ground radar aircraft.

